



The Lovely and the Liminal

A threshold can divide rooms, memories, identities, and stages of a life. This guide moves through the strange beauty of places that are designed for passage, then asks what happens when the passage becomes a world.

Reading “liminal” with enough precision to keep it useful

The Latin word *limen* means threshold. In social theory, liminality names a middle phase in which an earlier status has been left but a new one has not yet been secured. Online, the word often describes empty schools, fluorescent corridors, hotel carpets, foggy car parks, and other familiar places that feel detached from their normal use. Psychology adds another route: crossing a spatial boundary can change the information the mind keeps readily available.

Those meanings overlap, but they are not interchangeable. A railway station is architecturally transitional even when it is crowded and cheerful. A person awaiting a ceremony is socially between recognised identities even without standing in an uncanny room. A surreal painting can disturb ordinary categories without depicting a threshold at all. The section becomes interesting when scholars name the particular in-between condition instead of using “liminal” as a synonym for anything strange.

The official links are essential because liminality has to be experienced as well as defined. The Backrooms short film removes the expected destination from office-like corridors. *POOLS* makes a player move through echoing rooms without conventional goals. Paintings and photographs show railways as speed, crowd, atmosphere, and social theatre. Literature stretches a temporary wait into a condition of life. Ambient music changes attention without demanding the foreground. Read, watch, look, and listen before deciding what each work’s threshold actually is.

Chapter 1 - What in-between really means

The doorway effect begins with a joke nearly everyone understands: you enter a room and forget why you went there. The official prompt calls the doorway a liminal threshold and suggests that the mind “resets.” That is a useful image, but the linked experiment gives a more careful account. Memory is organised around events, and a boundary can signal that one event has ended and another has begun.

What the experiment compared

In the [Scientific American explanation of the doorway effect \(L100\)](#), participants moved objects in a virtual environment. Sometimes they crossed a room; sometimes they travelled the same distance through a doorway into another room. At selected moments they were asked which object they were carrying. Responses after crossing a doorway were slower and less accurate than responses after equivalent movement within one room.

The researchers also tested real rooms and found a similar pattern. Another condition returned participants to the original room after they had crossed two doorways. If forgetting came only from being in a different physical context, returning should have restored the advantage. It did not. The interpretation was that the boundary encouraged the mind to update an “event model,” reducing immediate access to information associated with the preceding event.

This is not proof that every doorway causes amnesia or that the brain empties short-term memory. Attention, task complexity, intention strength, familiarity, and individual differences matter. “Reset” is a metaphor for a change in accessibility, not a delete command. A scholar should preserve the experiment’s comparison: same distance, different event boundary.

Events need boundaries because attention is limited

The mind cannot keep every detail equally ready. It groups continuous experience into meaningful events: making breakfast, leaving home, travelling to school, beginning a class. Boundaries may be spatial, temporal, social, or goal-based. A door is a strong cue because new rooms often contain new actions and objects. Finishing a conversation, switching applications, or being interrupted can create a similar transition.

This explains why the effect is usually useful. Information from the old event becomes less urgent when a new setting demands attention. The comic failure occurs when one intention must survive the boundary but is treated as belonging to what came before. Carrying the object, repeating the intention, or writing a reminder can bridge the event.

Three meanings of liminality

Spatial liminality belongs to a route. A corridor, lift, bridge, airport, or waiting room connects places and is normally occupied temporarily. Social liminality belongs to a change of status. Anthropologist Arnold van Gennep described rites of passage through separation, transition, and incorporation; Victor Turner later developed the middle phase as a period in which ordinary roles may loosen. Psychological liminality is broader and less formal: a person between schools, homes, careers, relationships, or stages of recovery may feel that an old identity no longer fits while a new one remains uncertain.

Internet liminal aesthetics borrow from all three. Images often remove the people and purposes that make a place legible. A classroom at night is still a classroom, but without students, time cues, or a visible exit, it can feel like a memory of a category rather than an active place. The uncanniness comes from recognition without normal explanation.

Liminal does not mean empty

Anthropological liminality can be crowded, ceremonial, and highly structured. Participants may wear special clothing, follow instructions, and form an intense temporary bond because ordinary ranks have loosened. Turner used the term *communitas* for a form of direct fellowship that can emerge in such intervals. Whether it actually appears depends on the rite and its power relations; not every transition makes people equal.

This is an important correction to the online aesthetic. An empty corridor can suggest liminality, but emptiness is neither necessary nor sufficient. Frith's crowded station later in this guide is transitional because many routes cross there. A graduation hall is liminal because a recognised status change is underway even when every seat is occupied. Analyse the process that suspends or changes roles, not the number of people in the image.

A threshold changes what "there" means

Before crossing, the destination belongs to the future. After crossing, the place may become ordinary so quickly that the previous intention fades. The year theme's question can therefore be cognitive: how does the mind decide that one episode is over and another has begun? Arrival is not only a coordinate. It is an update in the model of what matters now.

That update can be chosen or imposed. A graduation ceremony marks a status change publicly. A refugee crossing a border may enter a legal and personal in-between that no ceremony resolves. A patient awaiting test results inhabits uncertain time. Calling all three "liminal" can reveal a pattern, but analysis must name differences in duration, power, and consequence.

How to test the word

When a new example appears, identify the before-state and after-state. Name the threshold or transition process. Ask which ordinary rules are suspended and whether the suspension is temporary. Then explain how the in-between changes memory, identity, behaviour, or feeling. If no credible before, after, or threshold can be identified, another word such as surreal, ambiguous, isolated, nostalgic, or uncanny may be better.

Precision does not remove beauty. It lets scholars compare why an empty airport and an initiation ritual can both feel suspended without pretending they are the same experience. Liminality is powerful because it describes structure: departure has happened, incorporation has not.

A small diagram in the mind helps: before, boundary, after. For the doorway experiment, the before-state is carrying an intention inside one event model, the boundary is the change of room, and the after-state is a newly updated context in which the intention is less accessible. For a social rite, the boundary can last days or months and include rules, teachers, ordeals, or waiting. When the middle grows indefinitely, it may no longer function as a passage at all. That failure becomes the subject of Chapter 4.

Sources for this chapter: the official [doorway-effect account \(L100\)](#), including its virtual, real-room, and return-to-context conditions. The social definition draws on the established separation-transition-incorporation framework; the guide treats "reset" as an explanatory metaphor, not literal deletion of memory.

Chapter 2 - Architecture built for passing through

Stations, trains, elevators, and waiting rooms are not blank containers around travel. They organise bodies, clocks, information, and expectations. Their architecture teaches people where to queue, when to move, whom to watch, and how long uncertainty should feel acceptable. The official works make that social machinery visible across more than 170 years.

Turner makes speed enter the landscape

In J. M. W. Turner's *Rain, Steam, and Speed - The Great Western Railway* (1844, L104), a locomotive advances across Isambard Kingdom Brunel's Maidenhead Railway Bridge. Rain, smoke, steam, and paint dissolve the boundary between machine and atmosphere. The bridge's abrupt perspective pulls the viewer toward the train, making speed a visual force rather than a label.

The National Gallery notes a lightly painted hare on the track, now difficult to see because the paint has become more transparent. Natural and mechanical speed meet in one narrow route. The painting is not easily reduced to a rejection of industry. Turner used modern transport and treated the train and bridge as subjects worthy of ambitious painting. The liminality lies in a landscape being transformed by movement and in the viewer positioned between fascination and danger.

Frith turns the station into a social panorama

The curriculum names William Powell "Firth," but the linked Royal Collection record correctly identifies William Powell **Frith**. His *The Railway Station* (1862, L105) crowds a large interior with travellers, workers, luggage, reunions, separations, and class signals. The station is not empty or anonymous. It is a stage on which private stories briefly share one public timetable.

Frith's detailed groups reward narrative looking. Some people are leaving, some arriving, and some remain because working in the station is their destination. This challenges the simple claim that a liminal space belongs to nobody. A platform is temporary for the passenger and routine for the porter. Liminality depends on the user's relation to the space.

Railways carry modernity into different visual cultures

Tsukioka Yoshitoshi's *Picture of the Railroad at Takanawa* (1871, L106) depicts the railway just before Japan's first line opened between Shimbashi and Yokohama in 1872. The woodblock print places new transport within a familiar print medium. Railway, shoreline, boats, and distant city make technological transition visible before the system has become ordinary.

Claude Monet's *The Gare St-Lazare* (1877, L107) moves inside the terminal. Iron roof girders form dark geometry while steam turns an industrial interior into changing atmosphere. The National Gallery identifies it as one of twelve station views Monet painted that year. Light and cloud, conventions of outdoor landscape, appear under glass and iron. The station becomes both machine and weather.

The Yilan folk song "*Drip, Drip, Drip*" (L108), also known through romanisations such as "Diu Diu Tong," connects rail travel with sound and local memory. Its onomatopoeic refrain is associated with droplets encountered as a train passes through a tunnel. Unlike the paintings, the route is carried in voice and rhythm. A tunnel briefly removes the wider landscape, and sound marks motion through the enclosed threshold.

A station can be theatre, image, and workplace

Steve McCurry's *Train Station, Agra, 1983* (L109) belongs to his extended journey on South Asian railways. The linked account describes the Agra Fort station at dusk, with the Jama Masjid mosque silhouetted beyond the train and an attendant adjusting a ventilator on a carriage. McCurry called the station a theatre where every kind of life appears.

The photograph's threshold is layered. The carriage is about to move, the light is changing, the worker is performing maintenance, and the religious and transport architectures share the frame. Yet a scholar should also ask who photographs whom. A traveller's image of a busy station can turn working lives into visual atmosphere. Liminal beauty does not cancel the unequal positions of observer and observed.

The elevator becomes an artwork while remaining an elevator

Richard Artschwager's *Six in Four* (2015, L110) transforms four elevators in the Whitney Museum of American Art. The title refers to six recurring subjects in Artschwager's work - door, window, table, basket, mirror, and rug - distributed through four immersive lift interiors. Visitors encounter the commission while moving to another gallery.

This is liminal art in a precise architectural sense. The museum does not ask everyone to stop in front of a separate object. Functional transit becomes the exhibition. The doors close, the view changes, and the artwork ends when the destination floor opens. Repeated visitors may experience different elements without scheduling a special encounter.

Waiting rooms design uncertainty

The official [history of transitional "non-places"](#) (L111) describes waiting rooms as political and social architectures. A doctor's horseshoe of chairs directs strangers toward one another and the door. A government waiting area can sort people by legal category. Number screens, reception desks, closed doors, and rows of seats distribute information and authority.

The linked article on [waiting-room anxiety](#) (L112) focuses on colour, sound, seating, nature, and information. It is an accessible design discussion rather than strong clinical evidence, so use its claims as hypotheses. More robust principles can still be reasoned from the task: uncertainty feels worse when people do not know how long they will wait, whether they have been forgotten, or what will happen next. Clear check-in, progress information, privacy, comfortable seating, daylight, acoustic control, and visible staff can reduce some of that uncertainty.

Different purposes demand different rooms. An emergency department needs infection control, observation, triage, and room for distress. A child clinic may need play without overwhelming noise. A visa office needs clear document preparation and fair queue information. A bereavement setting needs privacy. "Calming" is not one universal colour palette; it is a relationship between design and the reason people are waiting.

Architecture sets the terms of temporary belonging

Across the works, movement becomes modern speed, social crowd, atmospheric uncertainty, national transition, labour, and art. The station is temporary for some and permanent work for others. The elevator is a few seconds of passage transformed into cultural encounter. The waiting room can make equal order visible or expose unequal bureaucracy.

When analysing a new transit space, ask how the architecture communicates time, direction, status, and control. Who can sit? Who can see the next step? Whose language appears on the sign? What happens when a delay becomes long? The beauty of a threshold is inseparable from whether people can move through it with dignity.

Four railway works, four models of historical time

Turner paints the train as an event bursting into the present. The viewer confronts a machine moving faster than familiar animal speed. Yoshitoshi's print places new railway infrastructure inside a medium with its own established visual traditions, so technological change is seen through cultural continuity. Monet paints after the railway has become everyday enough to study repeatedly; modernity is now atmosphere, work, and changing light. McCurry photographs a mature network whose colonial construction history, national symbolism, maintenance labour, and ordinary passengers occupy the same station.

These differences prevent a single story in which railways simply represent progress. A line can connect cities and reorganise land, labour, time zones, class relations, military power, and access. The official artworks do not document all those effects by themselves, but they train scholars to ask which stage of arrival an image records: astonishing innovation, cultural transition, normalised infrastructure, or inherited system. The Yilan song adds memory from

inside the journey, where the tunnel is known through echo and dripping sound rather than seen from an outside viewpoint.

Compare the frame, not only the subject

Turner's diagonal bridge makes the viewer face the approaching engine. Monet's station roof encloses steam and disperses attention among platforms. Frith offers enough detail to scan separate social stories. McCurry uses dusk and silhouette to suspend one working gesture. Artschwager removes the distant viewpoint entirely: the visitor's body enters the commissioned lift and completes the movement. Every work depicts transit, but each assigns the viewer a different position - endangered observer, atmospheric witness, social reader, photographic traveller, or actual passenger.

This is a strong official-round method. Identify where the work places you, what information that position permits, and what it hides. A station map viewed from above creates mastery. A platform photograph creates partial waiting. An elevator installation gives no wide overview because its duration and enclosure are the work. Perspective is one of the tools by which liminality becomes felt.

A design audit for waiting

Visit or remember two waiting spaces and reconstruct the sequence. How does a person know they have checked in? Can they estimate the wait? Is the next name announced publicly, displayed visually, sent privately, or all three? Where can someone ask for help without losing a place? Are toilets, water, charging, interpretation, and quiet available? Does furniture assume one body size and one way of sitting?

Then separate anxiety caused by the future event from anxiety added by the room. A clinic cannot make a diagnosis unfrightening through paint colour, but it can avoid uncertainty about whether the patient was forgotten. A migration office cannot make a legal decision harmless through music, but it can give clear multilingual steps and protect private conversation. Good threshold design does not disguise power. It makes the process legible and reduces unnecessary suffering around it.

Sources for this chapter: every official shared-space link, from Turner's *Rain, Steam, and Speed* (L104), Frith's *Railway Station* (L105), Yoshitoshi's *Takanawa railway* (L106), Monet's *Gare St-Lazare* (L107), the Yilan folk song (L108), McCurry's *Agra station image* (L109), and Artschwager's *Six in Four* (L110), through the two waiting-room sources L111 and L112.

Chapter 3 - The uncanny ordinary

Liminal horror rarely begins with a castle or monster. It begins with a place that should be understandable: an office corridor, play area, hotel, basement, or swimming pool. The lights work and the carpet looks familiar, yet signs of purpose and human use are missing. The viewer recognises the category without being able to complete the situation.

The Backrooms remove the promise of the corridor

Kane Parsons, known online as Kane Pixels, released *The Backrooms (Found Footage)* in 2022 (L101). The short film presents fictional footage dated 1996. A camera operator falls into an apparently endless interior of yellow walls, fluorescent lighting, damp-looking carpet, and repeating turns. The corridor's usual function is to connect rooms, but here each passage produces more passage.

The found-footage form narrows knowledge. The camera shakes, looks late, and records only what a frightened person could see. Visual noise and an old recording date make the image feel discovered rather than composed. Off-screen sound creates a threat before its source can be understood. The viewer shares the operator's route and lack of map.

The horror is not emptiness by itself. An empty office during cleaning can feel calm because its time and purpose remain legible. The Backrooms remove ordinary explanations, reliable exits, and social witnesses. Familiar architecture continues after the story that once justified it has vanished. This is "not there yet" made terrifying because every step repeats the condition instead of reducing it.

POOLS creates pressure without a pursuer

The game *POOLS* (L102) describes itself through dreamlike rooms filled with pools. Its official site emphasises that there are no monsters, dialogue, conventional user interface, background music, or normal story notes. Water slows movement. Echo and sound change with the room. Architecture shifts as the player advances.

Removing a visible enemy makes perception the main activity. The player listens for a threat that the game says is absent, notices dark openings, and worries about being lost. Blue water, tiles, slides, stairways, and changing light recall leisure spaces, but nobody is playing or supervising. The environment has the form of hospitality without the social system that would make it safe.

Interactivity changes liminality. A film viewer can wait for the editor to reveal the route. A player must choose the next opening, accept slower movement in water, and take responsibility for entering a narrow space. The game turns uncertainty into an action without giving that action a conventional goal.

The Stanley Parable makes the route argue back

The Stanley Parable (L103) begins when an office worker finds that his colleagues have vanished. A narrator describes what Stanley does, but the player can obey or resist. Doors, corridors, lifts, and offices become arguments about choice. An ending may restart the game, and a choice may reveal that the narrator already anticipated rebellion.

The official site calls it an exploration of story, games, and choice, then undermines each category. That self-contradiction is the core mechanic. Stanley is between employee and player-character; the player is between author and subject; the office is between workplace and stage set. Arrival never settles authority because the game can reinterpret the route after each ending.

Unlike *The Backrooms*, this uncanniness is often comic. Both works remove colleagues from an office environment, but one threatens the body while the other destabilises authorship. A liminal setting does not dictate one emotion. The work's rules, sound, camera, and relationship to choice determine whether uncertainty becomes fear, curiosity, humour, or critique.

Why abandoned and foggy places work so well

Architecture stores expectations. A school implies students, a pool implies swimmers, and a hotel implies staff and guests. Remove the people while keeping lights, furniture, and signs, and the mismatch demands an explanation. Fog shortens visibility, so the destination cannot organise present movement. Repetition weakens landmarks. Transitional spaces are especially effective because their meaning already depends on somewhere else.

Digital environments add impossible geometry. A corridor can loop without fitting inside a building. Doors can reload space. A narrator can remember a route the player reset. These violations are disturbing because they break the learned rules by which bodies predict safety.

Do not call every empty image liminal

An unoccupied room can be documentary, peaceful, neglected, or simply closed. A useful liminal reading identifies suspended purpose and unresolved movement. In *The Backrooms*, the endless route has no reliable destination. In *POOLS*, recreational forms remain while users and normal goals disappear. In *The Stanley Parable*, office circulation becomes a choice system whose endings refuse finality.

This standard keeps analysis from becoming a mood label. Describe the missing social script, the spatial rule that fails, and the effect on the viewer or player. The uncanny ordinary is not strange despite being familiar. It is strange because familiarity generates expectations that the work carefully denies.

Sound, repetition, and agency create three different traps

The Backrooms uses the camera's incomplete hearing to imply pursuit outside the frame. *POOLS* gives environmental sound physical logic: echoes change with space and footsteps slow in water, so realism makes impossible architecture more convincing. *The Stanley Parable* replaces the hidden monster with an audible narrator who interprets the player's action. In each work, sound tells the user whether the space recognises them, but the answer differs: something may be hunting, the room may be indifferent, or the story may be arguing back.

Repetition also performs different work. Yellow corridors erase landmarks, poolrooms vary just enough to make memory uncertain, and office routes repeat after endings while carrying knowledge from earlier play. The first weakens orientation, the second sustains exploratory attention, and the third turns repetition into commentary on choice. Scholars should name these mechanisms rather than concluding that all three games are effective because liminal spaces are "creepy."

Agency completes the comparison. The found-footage operator appears to choose under panic, the *POOLS* player explores without a conventional objective, and Stanley's player can disobey a narrator who may convert disobedience into another authored route. Increasing control does not guarantee arrival. Sometimes the work gives choice precisely so the limits of choice can be felt.

Sources for this chapter: the official *Backrooms* short film ([L101](#)), the developer's *POOLS* site ([L102](#)), and the official *Stanley Parable* description ([L103](#)). Their shared architecture supports different emotional and narrative mechanisms.

Chapter 4 - Rites, thresholds, and unstable identities

Liminality is meant to be temporary. A traveller waits for a train, a candidate completes an initiation, and a guest eventually leaves the hotel. The works in this branch ask what happens when the expected incorporation never comes. Waiting can empty life, create solidarity, sharpen attention, produce humiliation, or become the condition in which a new self is made.

Waiting for Godot: repetition without arrival

Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*, including the curriculum's Scene 2 (L120), keeps Vladimir and Estragon beside a road and tree while the expected Godot does not arrive. They talk, argue, remember imperfectly, consider leaving, and remain. The second act repeats much of the first with changes that make time both undeniable and difficult to measure.

The waiting is active theatre. Small routines prevent silence and give the pair reasons to continue. A messenger renews expectation, so disappointment does not become a final ending. The road promises movement, but the characters' shared promise fixes them in place. This is a powerful model of delayed arrival because hope sustains the condition that hope is supposed to end.

Neruda's stillness is a chosen interval

Pablo Neruda's "*Keeping Still*" (L121) imagines a brief, shared pause in habitual activity. It is not an argument for permanent inactivity or death. The poem distinguishes stillness from total withdrawal and presents the interval as a chance to interrupt violence, labour, and misunderstanding long enough to perceive another possibility.

Placed beside Beckett, the poem shows that duration and agency matter. Vladimir and Estragon cannot convert waiting into arrival. Neruda's collective pause is deliberately bounded and valuable because normal action will resume differently. Both suspend ordinary motion, but one is an unresolved dependency and the other a reflective practice.

A platform turns romantic hope into public exposure

Philippe Orreindy's short film *I'll Wait for the Next One...* (2002, L122) takes place in the Paris Metro. A man makes a public announcement that appears to seek love, and a woman decides whether to respond. The next train supplies a literal deadline. The platform is a place where strangers briefly share attention, then disperse.

The film uses that temporary public to make vulnerability visible. A private desire becomes a performance under the eyes of commuters. Waiting for the next train also becomes waiting for another chance, but transport time is indifferent to emotional readiness. The exact plot turn should be watched rather than spoiled by a guide; its value lies in how a scheduled departure converts hesitation into consequence.

Walking through walls does not abolish boundaries

Marcel Aymé's "*The Man Who Could Walk through Walls*" (L123) follows Dutilleul, an ordinary Paris clerk who discovers he can pass through solid barriers. At first the gift barely changes his conventional life. Humiliation at work encourages him to use it, and freedom from walls expands into rebellion, crime, and a new public identity.

The story makes physical thresholds optional while social and psychological ones intensify. Dutilleul can cross a locked surface but cannot remain outside consequence. His ability eventually fails at the moment when passage matters most, leaving him trapped in the material boundary he once treated as meaningless. The fantasy proves that a threshold is more than an obstacle. It organises restraint, privacy, temptation, and identity.

The official page dates the story's collection to 1943, rather than the 1941 date printed in the curriculum line. Scholars should remember the discrepancy instead of forcing false agreement. A publication date is a factual detail; the mechanism of the story remains the reversal from effortless passage to permanent entrapment.

The hotel becomes a whole world

In Amor Towles's *A Gentleman in Moscow* excerpt (L124), Count Alexander Rostov is sentenced in 1922 to lifelong house arrest in Moscow's Metropol Hotel. A hotel is normally a temporary home between journeys. The sentence turns it into the boundary of an entire life.

The opening movement makes the change architectural. Rostov is taken from his grand suite to a small attic room formerly used for servants. He must choose which possessions can fit. Status, space, and political order change together. The hotel remains open to travellers and historical change while he cannot cross its outer threshold.

Confinement does not freeze identity. Within the building, relationships, work, observation, and responsibility give time shape. This distinguishes the novel from a simple prison narrative. The passage-space becomes a community and vantage point. A person may not reach the expected destination yet still build a meaningful route inside the limit.

Temporary suspension can liberate or dominate

Rites of passage often loosen ordinary roles under recognised rules and then return participants to society with a new status. The five works remove or complicate that guarantee. Godot does not arrive. The shared pause is only an imagined possibility. A train leaves on schedule regardless of emotional outcome. A supernatural ability crosses walls until it cannot. A hotel stay becomes a sentence.

Power determines whether liminality is chosen. A retreat, gap year, or quiet interval can support reflection because the person has resources and an exit. Detention, bureaucratic delay, displacement, and indefinite waiting impose uncertainty. Describing both as liminal should not flatten the difference between seeking an interval and being denied incorporation.

Sources for this chapter: all five official “stuck” works: *Waiting for Godot* (L120), Neruda's “Keeping Still” (L121), Orreindy's *I'll Wait for the Next One...* (L122), Aymé's wall-walker story (L123), and the *Gentleman in Moscow* excerpt (L124). Summaries avoid reproducing protected text and focus on each work's threshold mechanism.

Chapter 5 - Why the liminal can be lovely

A threshold is often valued only for what lies beyond it. Kant's aesthetics offers a way to understand why a place without a practical destination can still command attention. He describes judgments of beauty as disinterested and as responding to a form that seems purposive without serving one determinate purpose. The Stanford Encyclopedia's [account of Kant's aesthetics](#) and the [Internet Encyclopedia overview](#) make the claim more precise than "beauty is useless."

A viewer can experience an arrangement as fitting, ordered, or alive without needing it to accomplish a task or satisfy a private desire. Liminal spaces may invite this attention because their ordinary use is paused. An empty concourse no longer functions only as a route to a gate; light, repetition, distance, and sound become available as form. Yet beauty is not guaranteed. A hostile waiting room can be purposeless to the viewer and still remain ugly, frightening, or unjust.

Seven works test whether "liminal" has become too broad

Paul Gauguin's [Where Do We Come From? What Are We? Where Are We Going? \(1897-98, L113\)](#) stages human life through figures often read from birth toward age and death. Its title makes transition explicit, but formal analysis must sit beside colonial context. Gauguin painted the work in Tahiti and built an exoticised visual world through a European artist's position. Calling the painting liminal can illuminate life-stage questions while obscuring the power through which the setting was represented.

René Magritte's [The Treachery of Images \(1929, L114\)](#) places a painted pipe beside words explaining that the image is not the object. The work sits between representation, language, and thing. It is conceptually unstable, but not necessarily liminal in the spatial or ritual sense. If scholars use the term, they should name the threshold between sign and referent rather than relying on surreal mood.

Salvador Dalí's [The Persistence of Memory \(1931, L115\)](#) makes hard watches limp within a sharply rendered dreamscape. MoMA explains that Dalí used precise illusion to disrupt ordinary reality and associated the soft watches with a collapse of fixed time. Dreaming is often described as a threshold between waking and sleep, but the painting does not need the word "liminal" to be understood. Surreal transformation and unstable time may be more exact.

Andrew Wyeth's [Christina's World \(1948, L116\)](#) shows Christina Olson in a field looking toward distant buildings. MoMA notes the muscular condition that left Olson unable to walk and Wyeth's effort to represent her life. The field is a difficult interval between body and home, but treating the figure as a symbol of vague distance can erase disability and agency. A responsible liminal reading must keep the real person and material effort present.

M. C. Escher's [Ascending and Descending \(1960, L117\)](#) locks figures onto an impossible staircase that appears to rise or fall forever. This is a strong case of movement without arrival. The architecture is mathematically contradictory rather than socially transitional, so "impossible loop" may be the primary concept and liminality the thematic connection.

Gregory Crewdson's [Beneath the Roses series \(L118\)](#) stages elaborately produced scenes in ordinary American streets and interiors. Cinematic lighting and suspended action make familiar places look as if something has just happened or is about to happen. The before and after remain outside the frame. Here liminality works as narrative suspension, although "uncanny" and "staged" explain how the effect is produced.

Camille Seaman's [The Distant is Imminent \(2020, L119\)](#) projects polar images and a possible 2050 water line onto walls in cities threatened by rising seas. The artwork collapses a distance between remote ice and local future risk. Its threshold is political time: the city is not yet underwater, but present choices shape whether the projected line becomes lived reality.

A precision test for the popular meaning

The seven works demonstrate why “liminal” can become too broad. Each unsettles a boundary, but the boundaries differ: life stages, image and object, waking and dream, body and destination, possible and impossible movement, before and after, present and future. If the analysis cannot name that relationship, the label contributes little.

Use the most specific concept first. Magritte examines representation. Dalí destabilises time and material reality. Escher constructs an impossible loop. Seaman makes future climate consequence spatially present. Then explain whether a liminal structure connects that concept to the section. This method preserves both the popular aesthetic and the academic usefulness of the word.

Comparisons reveal which threshold each artwork needs

Gauguin and Seaman both use questions about a route through time, but they point in opposite directions. Gauguin gathers birth, adulthood, age, and existential questioning into a symbolic field whose cultural setting requires colonial scrutiny. Seaman takes a measurable future risk and projects it onto present urban walls. One turns life into a broad philosophical cycle; the other turns a distant consequence into a local deadline. Calling both “about where we are going” is true but too weak. The mechanisms are symbolic staging and site-specific forecast.

Magritte and Escher each make a contradiction visible. Magritte separates an object from its representation: the painted pipe can resemble a pipe while remaining paint and canvas. Escher creates a staircase whose local steps look credible while the whole route is impossible. The first threshold lies between sign and thing; the second lies between local perception and global structure. This is exactly the kind of comparison a WSC question can transfer to maps, simulations, models, and progress indicators.

Wyeth and Crewdson both use a familiar American environment to hold narrative at a distance. Wyeth anchors the scene in Christina Olson’s real body and determined relation to the farmhouse, so the field is material effort rather than a generic dream. Crewdson constructs cinematic scenes with crews, lighting, and staged figures, deliberately withholding the event that would explain them. One image can be misread as symbolic if biography disappears; the other is built to solicit incomplete stories. The word “liminal” must not erase that distinction between documented life and manufactured suspense.

Dalí and Seaman make time visible through altered objects. Soft watches deny ordinary measurement, while a projected water line gives a future year a height on today’s wall. Dalí systematises confusion; Seaman tries to focus action. Their surfaces can both look dreamlike, yet their purposes differ. Kantian disinterested attention may help explain formal attraction, but Seaman’s work explicitly wants that attention to return to practical climate responsibility.

Ambient music designs the edge of attention

Brian Eno’s *Ambient 1: Music for Airports* (1978, listed by WSC as 1979, L125) was conceived in relation to airport atmosphere. Eno wanted music that could coexist with environmental sound and reward different levels of attention. Slow, repeated vocal and instrumental fragments do not drive toward a conventional climax. Time feels available rather than counted down by a pop-song structure.

The date discrepancy is worth keeping: the album was released in 1978, although some editions and listings use 1979. More important is the design question. Airport sound already includes announcements, engines, conversation, footsteps, and anxiety. Ambient music does not erase that environment. It changes the listener’s relation to waiting by offering events that can be noticed without punishing distraction.

Hiroshi Yoshimura’s *Music for Nine Postcards* (1982, L126) grew from music imagined for the Hara Museum’s architecture and views. Sparse keyboard tones leave room around themselves, like sonic objects placed beside windows. The album shows that ambient listening need not be attached to anonymous transit. It can frame a particular room and the act of looking outward.

Max Richter’s *Sleep* (2015, L127) extends for roughly eight hours and was designed in dialogue with an overnight sleep cycle. Listeners may attend, drift, or lose consciousness while the work continues. This makes the threshold between waking and sleep part of performance. The sleeping audience is not failing to listen in the ordinary concert sense; the work includes altered attention.

Musical form can refuse the countdown

A conventional song often establishes sections and returns that help a listener predict how close the ending is. Ambient works may use slow change, sustained tone, repetition with small variation, and long silence between events. The listener can enter after the beginning or stop before the end without losing a plot. That structure suits a terminal or gallery because arrivals, announcements, and conversations already impose their own clocks.

The three works do not create the same background. Eno composes for an anxious public transport environment, Yoshimura frames architecture and viewing, and Richter follows a bodily cycle over an extraordinary duration. Treating all of them as relaxing playlists would remove the place, attention, and time experiment that makes each work specific.

Background sound is not socially neutral

Music in a restaurant, shop, airport, or school can reduce awkward silence, mask conversation, establish identity, and influence perceived pace. It can also make speech harder to understand, overwhelm sensory-sensitive users, or turn a shared environment into compulsory listening. “Calm” music is not universally calming.

Ambient design should therefore allow quiet and difference. Volume, frequency, repetition, announcements, acoustic treatment, and access to quieter zones matter. A playlist cannot solve bad seating, uncertain delay, or hostile rules. Sound is one layer of the threshold, not a substitute for humane architecture.

Beauty without arrival

Liminal beauty often comes from attention released from a task. The station roof becomes weather, the empty pool becomes echo, the hotel corridor becomes rhythm, and the pause before sleep becomes music. This release can be restorative because the future stops demanding immediate action. It can also aestheticise abandonment, bureaucracy, or climate danger. The lovely and the liminal are partners, not synonyms.

A mature answer keeps both sides. Describe the formal pleasure of repetition, light, suspension, or sound. Then identify the material system and the people inside it. A waiting room may be visually elegant while someone waits for a frightening result. A projected sea line may be beautiful because it makes danger perceptible. Beauty can hold attention on a threshold without resolving what lies beyond it.

Sources for this chapter: Kant background from the [Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy](#) and [Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy](#); all seven official works from Gauguin’s [life-cycle painting \(L113\)](#) through Seaman’s [climate projection \(L119\)](#); and all three listening links, Eno’s [Music for Airports \(L125\)](#), Yoshimura’s [Music for Nine Postcards \(L126\)](#), and Richter’s [Sleep \(L127\)](#).

Final synthesis - A threshold deserves its own kind of attention

The section moves from a doorway in the laboratory to corridors without exits, railway spaces full of collective life, stories in which waiting becomes existence, and music that accompanies the edge of consciousness. The examples do not share one visual style. They share a structural question: what changes when departure has occurred but arrival cannot yet organise experience?

Liminality can free attention because normal purpose loosens. It can also expose power because somebody controls the queue, border, sentence, timetable, or definition of readiness. The difference between a restorative pause and indefinite suspension lies in duration, agency, knowledge, and access to an exit. Beauty may help people remain with uncertainty, but it does not make the uncertainty fair.

When an unfamiliar work or place appears in an official round, name the before-state, after-state, and threshold. Explain which normal rule is suspended. Identify who chose the interval and who can end it. Then describe the formal mechanism - repetition, empty architecture, unstable narration, light, sound, or delayed action - that makes the in-between felt. The best answer will not merely declare a mood “liminal.” It will show exactly what has been left, why arrival is withheld, and what becomes visible in the space between.